Ledgerleaf

Ledgerleaf: Executive Summary

Problem

Farmers' market vendors run small cash-and-card businesses from temporary stalls, often in locations with poor or no internet service. In conversations with 23 vendors at three markets near our university, 17 told us they record sales on paper or in a notebook and transfer the figures to a spreadsheet or to a bookkeeper days later. Twelve said they had at some point been unsure how much sales tax they owed for a given month. Paper tallies are easy to lose, and errors made while a line of customers waits are hard to catch afterward. The cost to a vendor is small per day but recurs every market day: time spent reconciling totals in the evening, and the risk of under- or over-reporting tax.

Solution

Ledgerleaf is an application for phones and tablets that works fully without a connection. A vendor sets up a short list of items and prices, taps to record each sale, and notes whether payment was cash or card. All data is stored on the device. When the device reaches a network, Ledgerleaf syncs the records to a secure account and backs them up. At the end of each market day the app shows total sales, sales by item, and the sales tax collected based on the vendor's local rate, which the vendor enters during setup. A monthly view gives a running estimate of tax owed so the vendor can set money aside. The interface is deliberately limited to a few large buttons so it can be used with one hand while serving customers.

Market

We estimate there are roughly 8,600 farmers' markets in the United States, based on publicly reported directory counts. If an average market hosts 30 vendors, that suggests about 258,000 vendor stalls, though many vendors sell at more than one market and some are hobbyists with little revenue. We believe a reasonable first target is full-time and serious part-time vendors, which we guess to be perhaps a third of the total, or around 85,000. We have not yet validated these figures with an independent source and treat them as rough. Our first target is the 40 markets within a two-hour drive of our university, representing roughly 1,200 vendors.

Business Model

Ledgerleaf will charge a subscription of $9 per month per vendor, with a free tier limited to one market day per week of stored history. If we convert 15 percent of vendors reached in our local region, that would be about 180 paying vendors and roughly $19,400 in annual recurring revenue. We also see potential to charge market managers for aggregated reports on vendor activity, though we have not tested whether managers would pay for this. Customer acquisition will rely on visits to markets, word of mouth among vendors, and partnerships with market associations. We have not yet measured acquisition cost.

Competition

Vendors currently use paper notebooks, general spreadsheets, and general-purpose point-of-sale and accounting products. Several of these products offer some offline capability, and many include sales reporting and tax features. Ledgerleaf differs by focusing narrowly on farmers' market workflows and by being simpler to operate at the stall. We recognize that a larger provider could add similar features, and that our product does not yet take card payments directly, which some competitors do. Our current advantage is focus and ease of use rather than any proprietary technology.

Team

Maribel Okonkwo-Reyes, chief executive, is a senior in business administration who spent two summers working a family stall at a regional market and conducted the vendor interviews. Tobias

Lindqvist-Hart, chief technology officer, is a senior in computer science and built the application, including its local storage and sync logic. Daniela Whitcombe, head of operations, is a junior in accounting who designed the tax estimation logic and the end-of-day report. All three founders are full-time students and work on Ledgerleaf alongside their coursework, averaging about 15 hours per week each.

Milestones and Financials

To date we have defined the core concept, registered the business name, built a working version of the application, and launched a website describing the product. Twelve vendors are using the product in a free trial, and one vendor, a honey and preserves seller, has paid for a subscription at $9 per month. Total revenue to date is $27. Our spending to date is approximately $640, funded personally by the founders, covering website hosting, a developer account for app distribution, and printed signage. We have not yet formed a legal entity for the venture and operate informally; incorporation is an early use of any funds we receive. Over the next twelve months we project reaching 100 paying vendors, though this depends on conversion from trial users, which we have not yet observed at scale. Our principal costs would be part-time contract development, app store fees, and travel to markets, which we estimate at $18,000 for the year.

What We Ask For

We are requesting $15,000 in competition funding. We would allocate $4,000 to legal formation and basic accounting setup, $6,500 to expanding the pilot to ten markets including vendor onboarding visits, $3,500 to contract development for card payment integration, and $1,000 to a vendor survey to better measure willingness to pay and acquisition cost. Beyond funding, we would value mentorship on pricing, on how to approach market associations, and on whether a subscription model is appropriate for vendors with highly seasonal income. Our goal at the end of the funding period is to demonstrate paid retention across several markets and to determine whether the business can reach sustainable revenue.